

Practice a skill you can observe

Choose a routine you can repeat. Track the decisions you improve rather than judging every session by a rating change.

A 25-minute study session	What to do
10 minutes: tactics	Solve a few positions carefully. Predict the defense and continuation before moving. Review the reason for every miss.
10 minutes: your own game	Revisit one critical position. Compare your choice with two alternatives and write the lesson in plain language.
5 minutes: an endgame	Repeat a basic mate, pawn race, or opposition position from both sides. Reset and retry if you need a hint.

Schedule games separately

For learning, choose a time control that lets you think through decisions; 15 minutes plus a 10-second increment is one workable option. During competitive games, rely on your own play. Use engines and study materials for training and post-game review.

Give puzzles a purpose

Work on a recurring weakness such as knight forks, loose pieces, or back-rank threats. Once the pattern becomes familiar, mix it with other themes so you must first recognize what kind of position you have.

Practice the entire line

Finding the first move is only part of solving a puzzle. Name the best defense and the final result. If you guessed correctly, repeat the exercise until you can explain why the alternatives fail.

A SMALL IMPROVEMENT TARGET

For the next ten games, focus on noticing undefended pieces before you move. Record how often you missed one. A specific habit is easier to practice than "play better."

SUGGESTED PRACTICE RESOURCE

Interactive tactics, checkmates, and endgames - lichess.org/practice

Review the decision, then the move

First analyze without an engine. Your own explanation reveals what you believed during the game and what you need to practice.

- 1. Mark the turning points.** Find moments where you faced a new threat, used a lot of time, changed the pawn structure, traded queens, or felt uncertain. Do not limit your review to the final blunder.
- 2. Rebuild your thought process.** Write the candidates you considered and the reply you expected. If you moved instantly, record the assumption that made the move feel safe.
- 3. Compare with analysis.** After your own attempt, use an engine or a stronger player to check the critical lines. Ask why a move works. A numerical evaluation alone does not explain the mistake.
- 4. Keep one usable lesson.** Describe the cause: missed defender, unsafe pawn push, poor time allocation, or wrong endgame assessment. Turn it into a question you can ask in the next game.

EXAMPLE OF A USEFUL NOTE

"I moved the knight that protected my rook. Before moving a defender, I will check the piece it leaves behind." This explains a repeatable error and a practical response.

Game / date / time control:

Critical move and what I expected:

Stronger alternative and the opponent's best reply:

One lesson to apply next game:

A four-week practice cycle

Treat this as a flexible starting plan. Repeat a week when a skill still feels uncertain, and keep using the move checklist throughout.

Week	Focus	A useful sign of progress
1	Blunder prevention and forks. Use the five questions from Guide 00.	You notice loose pieces and can explain why the fork in Guide 02 works.
2	Opening purpose and development. Review the first unfamiliar decision in each game.	You can explain your moves without relying only on an opening name.
3	King activity, pawn races, and basic mates. Practice both sides.	You calculate the side-to-move effect and finish a basic mate without stalemate.
4	Middlegame plans and trades. Review a position before and after an exchange.	You name a target, an improving move, and a reason the exchange helps or hurts.

Use your clock at the critical moments

Spend extra thought when the position changes: a pawn break, sacrifice, forcing sequence, or transition to an endgame. Avoid using most of your time choosing between similar quiet moves, then rushing the decisive calculation.

Keep a short error log

Use four columns: date, position or move number, cause, and next practice task. Look for the cause that repeats most often. Review it after a batch of games so a single win or loss does not distort the picture.

CLOSE THE LOOP

Play a thoughtful game, review one decision, practice the relevant pattern, then try again. Keep the lesson short enough that you can remember it when the next position appears.

COLLECTION NOTES

Interactive tactics, checkmates, and endgames - lichess.org/practice

Opening principles - [Chess.com](https://chess.com)

Original study notes, September 2026. Linked sources provide further practice and rule details.